

Preventing an AI Panopticon: Cognitive Sovereignty is the Next Frontier of Power

A multilingual application to support individuals protecting their cognitive sovereignty, learning from their experience with AI tools.

AI applications spill over into peoples' lives and threaten personal agency. I met Ninon Lizé Masclef at Foresight Institute's workshop in Seoul, a scientist reconstructing visual images from dreams' brainwaves. She discussed dream-inducing experiments and her concern about AI penetrating intimate parts of people's lives (their sleep), to control their cognitive capacities. The dual use ranges from health to commodification: supporting PTSD recovery to broadcasting advertisement.

The incorporation of AI tools or agents into people's lives raises concerns about allowing corporations or governments (depending on the decision-making locus) to control the third face of power. Coined by Lukes (1974), it is the capacity to manipulate opinions on what people consider desirable, similarly to media monopolies gradually manufacturing users' consent.

How can individual cognitive sovereignty be conserved in a society of AI hyper-consumers? Whether people opt in, or not, no longer matters as generated content floods the public space and digital platforms alike. Fast and insidious integration of AI into people's lives increases reliance on their capacity to optimise tasks, then schedules, then personal decisions. It is transformative for society and potentially irreversible. Consequently, developing personal early-warning systems to flag overreliance can support mindful deescalation.

A research paper would produce an evidence-based early-warning index and set-up an open-access tool with English, Mandarin, French and Spanish versions, to reach about a third of the world population.

The tool's final prototype will be designed to track time spent, number of requests and category of user query. The categorisation is inspired by Anthropic's index of "How people are using Claude" but would be based on the research results and assess the risk of dependency. If a user asks for personal advice, assessment will detect self-reflection in the text and the extent to which users consider the LLM's answers as a final decision. Recommendations are given based on consumption, level of offload and dependency.

The first month will be focused on researching causes, habits, risks and good practices for durable personal deescalation in dependency. Then, the second month, an online tool to flag and advise users will be created and put through a pilot trial with a small population, about 10 people per language group, and improved based on their advancements and feedback. The final month focus will be on drafting and editing the final research report and updating the tool to a fully functional and broadly accessible version.

Success would have two sides. First, running a pilot with 40 users with constructive self-reports on personal improvement in awareness and attitudes. Second, the submission of the paper to the CSCW conference. If the tool reaches a proven usefulness to counter people's dependency on AI tools, it would be worth sharing to support larger groups.

This project leverages political theory and behavioural analysis and searches for human solutions to rising AI challenges. It fits into the Cosmos Institute's focus on preserving human autonomy, as it is an intervention based on personal will to support people's emancipation from rising dependencies, while being inherently interdisciplinary.